UNIVERSITY OF CALIFORNIA, LOS ANGELES **UCLA**

BERKELEY • DAVIS • IRVINE • LOS ANGELES • RIVERSIDE • SAN DIEGO • SAN FRANCISCO

SANTA BARBARA • SANTA CRUZ

JOHN W. WALLACE, DISTINGUISHED PROFESSOR
DIRECTOR, Structural/Earthquake Engineering Research Laboratory

CIVIL & ENVIRONMENTAL ENGINEERING
5731 BOELTER HALL
LOS ANGELES, CALIFORNIA 90095-1593
TEL: (310) 206-7124 FAX: (310) 206-2222
wallacej@ucla.edu

Date: February 6, 2026

To: Evaluation Committee, UCLA Distinguished Teaching Assistant Award

Subject: Cover/Reference Letter: Samuel Halim

It is my pleasure to write this cover/nomination letter for Mr. Samual Halim who is a Ph.D. student under my supervision. The details of Sam's journey with respect to classroom teaching are well covered in his nomination letter and in his statement on teaching philosophy; therefore, I will not repeat this information but try to supplement it with my observations and student comments. Sam has been a TA for me in several classes, both at the undergraduate level (CEE 140L, a lab course) and for two graduate courses (CEE 243A and CEE 246, mostly MS students); therefore, I have detailed knowledge of his approach to teaching and of his performance as a TA.

Sam is exceptionally bright and an excellent researcher - foundational characteristics required to be a good TA, but insufficient by themselves to be a distinguished TA. Sam is always exceptionally well prepared, he really cares about the students, he is empathic, and he takes the time to reflect on his efforts and continuously improve. Sam regularly attended class lectures (although not required) and met with me weekly to discuss how best to integrate the discussion and lecture materials, before he would prepare his lesson plan. Sam also takes the time to develop the most effective way to present a topic, which is usually the simplest way. These qualities make Sam a distinguished TA. Student evaluation comments (a brief sample) consistently support my observations, such as:

Sam's a great TA and integrated the section with the course well. His example problems during discussion were very helpful in applying the class material. His office hours were useful. [CEE 243A, Fall 2025]

Out of all the classes and discussion sections, this one was the best. It was efficient, valuable, practical. We all felt it was very worth our time to go to discussions and class. … TA did an excellent job teaching material and leading discussions. I didn't miss a single one. [CEE 243A, Fall 2025]

Sam is amazing. His discussion sections were well organized and he was engaging. It was very obvious that he cared about the students and he made me want to go to class. I would 100% take another class with him. [CEE 243A, Fall 2024]

Sam was really knowledgeable about course material and the way he explained concepts was really helpful to me, his outlook on a lot of these topics and the way he digests information makes these concepts seem simple in the end which was really helpful to me. [CEE 140L, Spring 2025]

Samuel is by far the best TA I have had here at UCLA. HE is really good at explaining the concepts and also responds to emails in a timely manner. [CEE 246, Winter 2024].

The courses that Sam served as a TA for me are generally considered to be very challenging; therefore, having a knowledgeable and dedicated TA really improves student learning and UCLA's reputation. Sam is an exceptional candidate for this award.

Respectfully,

John Wallace

John W. Wallace, Distinguished Professor, Civil & Environmental Engineering

Nominee Statement

Samuel Halim | 406073724

I never thought that teaching would be something that I would look forward to. My reason to accept a Teaching Assistant (TA) position during my Bachelor's in Indonesia was to get additional income. However, the interaction with students and seeing their growth between each class that I taught gave me a rewarding feeling; I did not only find students to teach but also made friends along the way. Even after graduation, I had several encounters with my former students who still remembered how I used to teach (even some of my jokes) which helped them in their careers. This made me appreciate how a strong teaching relationship can affect someone's life.

When I began my graduate studies at UCLA as an international student, I observed and experienced the challenges students face trying to excel in the demanding classes, from heavy workload and different methods of study to having difficulties getting a response from the TA. However, I saw this as an opportunity to prepare myself to become a TA that is aware of what the students really need.

Over eight quarters as a TA at UCLA, my journey has not always been a smooth road. As teaching is held to such a higher standard at UCLA, my first time being a TA was really challenging. I had to make sure that my teaching methods were inclusive and attentive to the student learning experience. However, I had my struggles; there were some comments during class about my pace or the way the discussion was held that could be improved. Nevertheless, it did not demotivate me; it made me realize there was still room for improvement in my teaching. I started meeting with my professor every week to go over my discussion plans as well as analyzing the targeted feedback from students on my pacing and clarity. These efforts paid off when I observed that my average SET scores increased from 8.25/9.00 as a Teaching Assistant to 8.44/9.00 as a Teaching Fellow [Teaching Artifact #1].

From my experience being a TA at UCLA, I have identified my strengths that support student success:

1. **Proactive and Engaging.** I always tried to make my discussions into interactive sessions [Teaching Artifact #2]. Rather than presenting a finished solution to a problem, I "walked" with them by performing the calculations in real-time. I frequently asked the students to perform the calculations alongside me to increase participation as well as their confidence. By doing this, I also assessed the students that needed more explanation to understand. Furthermore, in one course, I tried to challenge the students by proposing to the instructor that

we incorporate a session of software (ETABS) demonstrations for the students, to get familiar with the commonly used software in industry [Teaching Artifact #3]. This “out of the box” session was successful in increasing the student participation and interest in the course.

2. **Inclusive Teaching.** Students come from different backgrounds and conditions, whether they need to commute, have work responsibilities, or have religious obligations, that might affect their access to in-person sessions. Therefore, I tried to make my discussions hybrid (in-person and remote) to accommodate the students who preferred to attend in-person sessions or remotely. Furthermore, I provided comprehensive material from my discussion (recording and notes) so that students could rewatch the session to support their learning experience [Teaching Artifacts #1 and #2].
3. **Supportive of Student Well-being.** Stress and anxiety are common in students, especially in rigorous disciplines like structural engineering. A student approached me saying that the student dropped a class because of the fear that they would not perform well. Although there was no requirement for a TA to intervene, I believe that being attentive to the student was necessary. I reassured them that my responsibility as a TA includes supporting all students regarding their learning progress in class, as I want every student to succeed. Encouraged by this support, the student got re-enrolled to finish the class [Teaching Artifacts #1 and #4].

In the end, being a great TA is not defined solely by having the greatest technical knowledge. It takes awareness, care, empathy, and the drive to be better for the student learning environment. I recognize that I still have room for growth, but I am proud of my journey from a student in Indonesia to a TA committed to support learning environments at UCLA. I would be honored to be considered for the Distinguished Teaching Assistant Award for the 2026 cycle.

Statement of Teaching Philosophy

Samuel Halim | 406073724

I have had some great teachers and mentors in my life. I believe they shaped not only my technical knowledge, but also my character and my confidence to push myself further. This made me realize how big of an impact a great mentor can have. Now that I am an educator myself, I have constructed the core principles I observed from my previous mentors to my own teaching.

My first fundamental principle in teaching is being able to explain concepts simply. This means the delivery should be direct and easy for students to understand, which increases their engagement and interest. I stick to this principle because I used to struggle with explanations that were far too complicated. Remembering that struggle, I make sure to deepen my own understanding so that I can explain things clearly. It is rewarding when students come up to me and say that after my explanation, a complicated problem now “seems simple in the end”.

My second principle is to be passionate about what I do. I realized that students could feel whether the teachers are passionate about what they do, which can generate their engagement towards the class. When you are passionate about something, you naturally put more effort into it, pay more attention to detail, and want to share that excitement with others. In this case, teaching is no longer seen as a burden, but as something I genuinely want to do.

My third principle is to create a safe and supportive learning environment. Often, students struggle because they don’t feel comfortable seeking help, which prevents them from getting the support they actually need. I remember how hard it was to work up the courage to ask a question in class because I was afraid of sounding stupid. Now, I tell my students that there is no such thing as a "stupid" question and that I am here to support them throughout the course; this helps build their confidence to speak up more. I want them to know that it is okay to be wrong, because in the end, I believe that making mistakes is a part of the progress toward a deeper understanding.

My next principle is not only to be technical, but also to be empathetic. It is important to realize that every student has different capabilities and learning styles. I have learned that a student’s struggle with a technical concept is often not a lack of ability, but perhaps a lack of confidence or a different way of processing information. Being empathetic helps me to tailor my support to meet them where they are. Whether a student is a visual learner who needs a sketch or someone who needs to talk through the logic step-by-step, I try to adjust my approach to fit their specific needs. I want my students to feel that I am not just grading their work, but that I actually care about them.

Lastly, as in other things in life, teaching is a continuous learning process. Realizing that I still have much to learn helps me stay grounded and prevents me from becoming stagnant in my methods. I have found that the best improvements often come from a two-way street between the instructor and the students. With this principle, I believe that teaching will benefit both the students and the teachers as well.

Overall, my teaching philosophy is centered on creating an open and supportive environment. Discussing struggles and anxiety shouldn't be taboo; it should be encouraged in a safe environment to help students excel. Finally, teaching is not about being a distant expert but about being a partner in learning. I hope that my teaching philosophy and goals align with UCLA. Let’s build a stronger community, one student and one lesson at a time.

Teaching Artifact #1: SET Surveys Scores and Feedback

Samuel Halim | 406073724

Average SET Surveys Scores for each step (out of 9.00)

To What Extent Do You Feel That:				Average
1 - Very Low or Never, 3 - Low or Infrequently, 5 - Average, 7 - High or Frequently, 9 - Very High or Always	Teaching Assistant	Teaching Associate	Teaching Fellow	
	S23 - W24	S24 - W25	S25 - F25	
Teaching Assistant Knowledge - The T.A. was knowledgeable about the material.	8.41	8.44	8.77	**8.54**
Teaching Assistant Concern - The T.A. was concerned about student learning.	8.31	8.23	8.48	**8.34**
Organization - Section presentations were well prepared and organized.	8.20	8.07	8.38	**8.22**
Scope - The teaching assistant expanded on course ideas.	8.23	8.06	8.29	**8.19**
Interaction - Students felt welcome in seeking help in or outside of the class.	8.21	8.29	8.40	**8.30**
Communication Skills - The teaching assistant had good communication skills.	8.14	8.25	8.30	**8.23**
AVERAGE	**8.25**	**8.22**	**8.44**	**8.30**

Student Comments and Feedback

Teaching Assistant (S23, F23, W24)

- Sam was amazing. He was very knowledgeable and was patient with questions. His discussions were always written before which increased visibility during class. He did a great job this quarter!
- Sam was very kind and approachable. He did a good job further explaining the more difficult subjects of the course. His discussions were always worth attending.
- Sam was wonderful. So knowledgeable, so kind, and replied to email with the precision that I hope every instructor learns from. I felt welcome to ask questions to him, and he always made sure to go above and beyond in answering these inquiries. I truly admire his hard work, his discussion notes got me through countless assignments, and I always made sure to make it to his discussions. The structure of his classes were clear, and he really tried to help with the group project and homeworks. I would love to take a class with him again if I could, and I would definitely seek him out if he were to be TA-ing another class. I can not give enough thanks to him for the work that he's done, and the endless patience he had with me as I bombarded him with questions weekly. Thank you for a wonderful class, and I wish him all the best in his endeavors.
- Sam is the TA I would often go to for help in office hours. He explained all the concepts and homework really well. I would go in feeling stuck and confused, and leave knowing how to solve the homework and with a better conceptual understanding. He also had a sense of humor and was fun to be around.
- Samuel is an excellent TA. Although he was the TA for the office hours and the review sessions, I felt very close to him and he was very welcoming. I went to almost every office hours to ask about the homework or concepts in class and Samuel answered every question. He also is very good at answer questions through email as well. I feel that Samuel really cares about the students' understanding of the material.

Teaching Associate (S24, F24, W25)

- Sam is the best TA I've had since he was so knowledgeable about the topics we learned in our class and explained everything thoroughly. I appreciated how he went through the steps to solve our homework assignments since it helped greatly when doing the assignments. Additionally, I appreciated how he took the time to show us how to use ETABS, which was helpful in showing me shortcuts and helpful in the longterm for when I start working in the industry.
- The TA was very useful and showed lots of concern for student learning, more than the instructor. I felt the course was a lot more manageable with the TA's discussion sections. The TA also helped with organizing the course as communication about exams and other class logistics wasn't clear and we had to get the TA to discuss scheduling with the instructor to get information on when exams would be during the quarter.
- I attribute a lot of my success in this course to Sam. He will always make himself available to help me, and I have a lot of fun learning from him. He knows the course material very well and comes prepared to all the discussion sections. I wish he could be my TA for a class next quarter :(. Sam is the best.
- Sam is a great TA that helps reinforce concepts from lecture. His discussion helped students understand the homework and how to approach solving it. I would want Sam as a TA in all my classes.
- Sam is one of the best TAs I have ever had and was very helpful in providing guidance on the homework. Additionally, I appreciated when he reviewed topics for our quizzes while also expanding on topics we learned in class.
- Sam is the best TA ever. If I am able to vote on TA of the year, I'd vote Sam. He does a great job explaining concepts to us and provides more than enough help with our assignments during discussion. Sam is very accommodating and is always willing to help. I enjoy his jokes in class too.

Teaching Fellow (S25, F25)

- Sam Halim, the TA for this course and a PhD student under Professor Wallace, was one of the greatest strengths of the class. He is very approachable, cheerful, and always willing to assist students both during lectures and office hours. Sam played a crucial role in bridging the gap between the advanced graduate-level material presented by Professor Wallace and our undergraduate understanding. His clear explanations and patient guidance were invaluable, especially when helping us with complex topics like anchorage development lengths and slenderness effects causing secondary moments in columns. He was also extremely supportive with lab reports, providing detailed feedback that helped improve both our technical understanding and report-writing skills. Without Sam’s help, many of us would have struggled to keep up with the course content. On the other hand, the course itself was challenging at times due to the high-level material and fast pace, which sometimes made it difficult to absorb everything fully. However, Sam’s dedication and expertise significantly mitigated these challenges, making the learning experience much more manageable and rewarding overall.

Out of all the classes and discussion sections, this one was the best. It was efficient, valuable, practical. We all felt is was very worth our time to go to discussions and class. Discussions were practical and relevant to class topics and homework assignments.
TA did an excellent job teaching material and leading discussions. I didn't miss a single one.

Homeworks were about right in workload. Grading is solid. Grading is done in a timely manner.

Overall good job. No real complaints.

I have only positive feedback for this teaching assistant. This teaching assistant was prompt, organized, and cared about student learning. The discussion sections were very correlated with the class lectures and homework assignments. The TA was communicative and prepared, responded to student emails quickly, and was helpful in office hours. I wish every course had a teaching assistant like this.

Discussions were very helpful in understanding the homework and applying topics in lecture to actual design problems. Overall, what you've been doing has been very good.

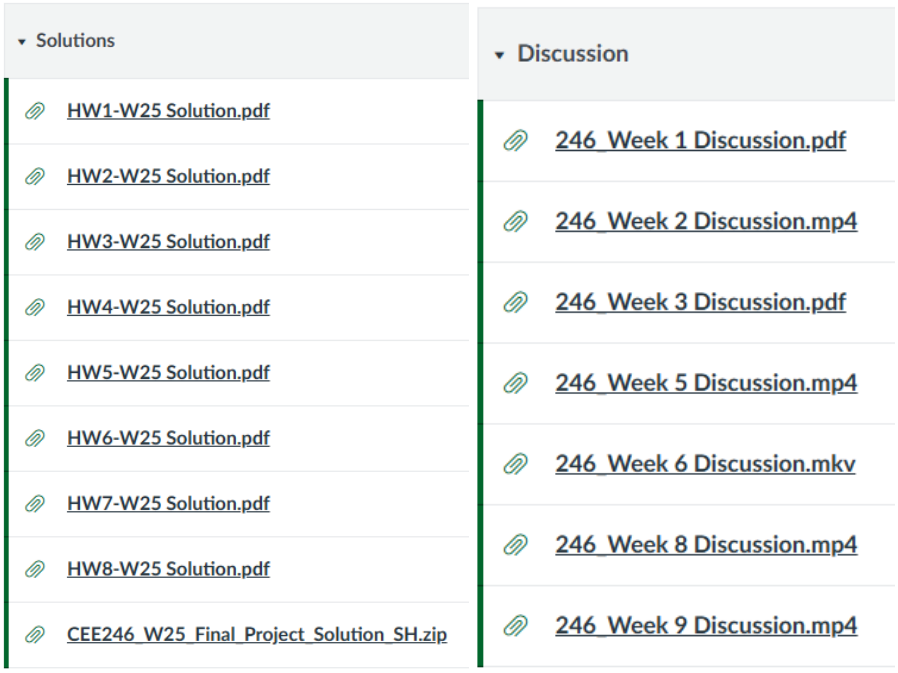
The TA has an impressive mastery of the subject and is always open to questions from students. He also proved he could step in for the instructor, teaching the class with even greater pedagogical skill.

Teaching Artifact #2: Organized Modules, Recordings, Solutions, and In-class Sessions

Samuel Halim | 406073724

Throughout my time as a Teaching Assistant, I have prioritized organization and accessibility to ensure my materials meet the diverse needs of every student. Recognizing that study habits, long commutes, and religious observances can often conflict with scheduled discussions, I committed to providing equal access to all notes and recorded lectures. This artifact demonstrates my dedication to an inclusive environment where no student is left behind due to external constraints. Beyond simple accessibility, I focused on fostering active learning by transforming in-class sessions into interactive, communal spaces where students are encouraged to proactively discuss and learn together.

Organized discussions recordings and homework solutions:



▾ Fall 2025 Solutions

- CEE 243A_Quiz#1 Solution_R0.pdf
- CEE 243A_Quiz#2 Solution_R0.pdf
- CEE 243A_Quiz#3 Solution_R0.pdf
- HW#1-F25_Solution_R0.pdf
- HW#2-F25_Solution_R0.pdf
- HW#3-F25 Solution_R0.pdf
- HW#4-F24 Solution_R0.pdf
- HW#5-F25 Solution_R0.pdf
- HW#6-F25 Solution_R2.pdf
- HW#7-F25 Solution_R0.pdf
- HW#8-F25 Solution_R0.pdf
- HW#8-F25 SolutionV2_R0.pdf
- HW#9-F25 Solution_R2.pdf

▾ Discussion

- 243A_Dis Week 1.pdf
- 243A_Dis Week 1.mp4
- 243A_Dis Week 2.mp4
- 243A_Dis Week 4.mp4
- 243A_Dis Week 6.mp4
- 243A_Dis Week 7.mp4
- 243A_Dis Week 8.mp4
- 243A_Dis Week 10.mp4

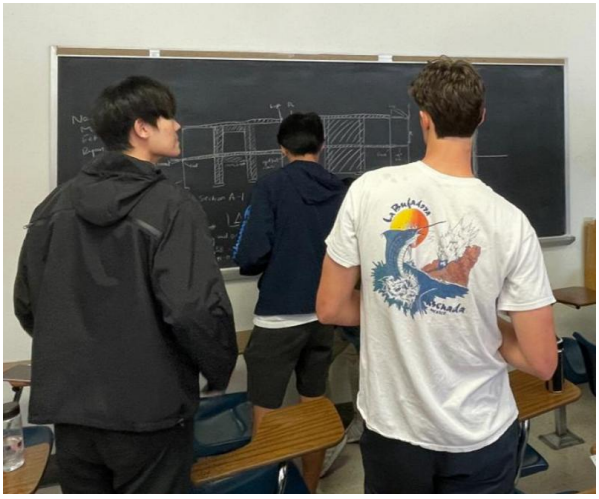
▾ Discussions

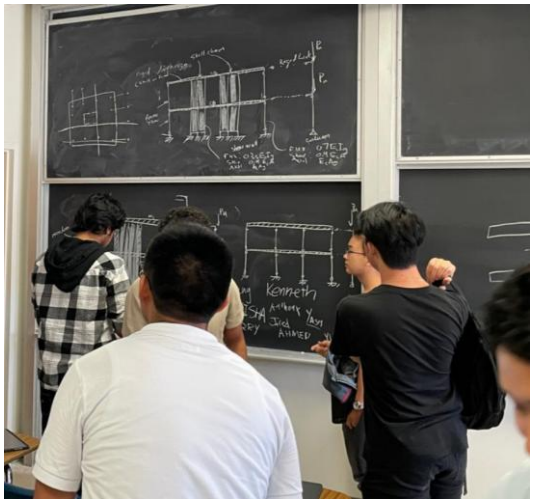
- Week 1.pdf
- Week 2.pdf
- Week 2.xlsx
- Week 3.pdf
- Week 4.pdf
- Week 5.pdf
- Week 6.pdf
- Week 7.pdf
- Week 8.pdf
- Week 9.pdf
- Week 10.pdf

In-class sessions made organized and proactive (CEE243A):



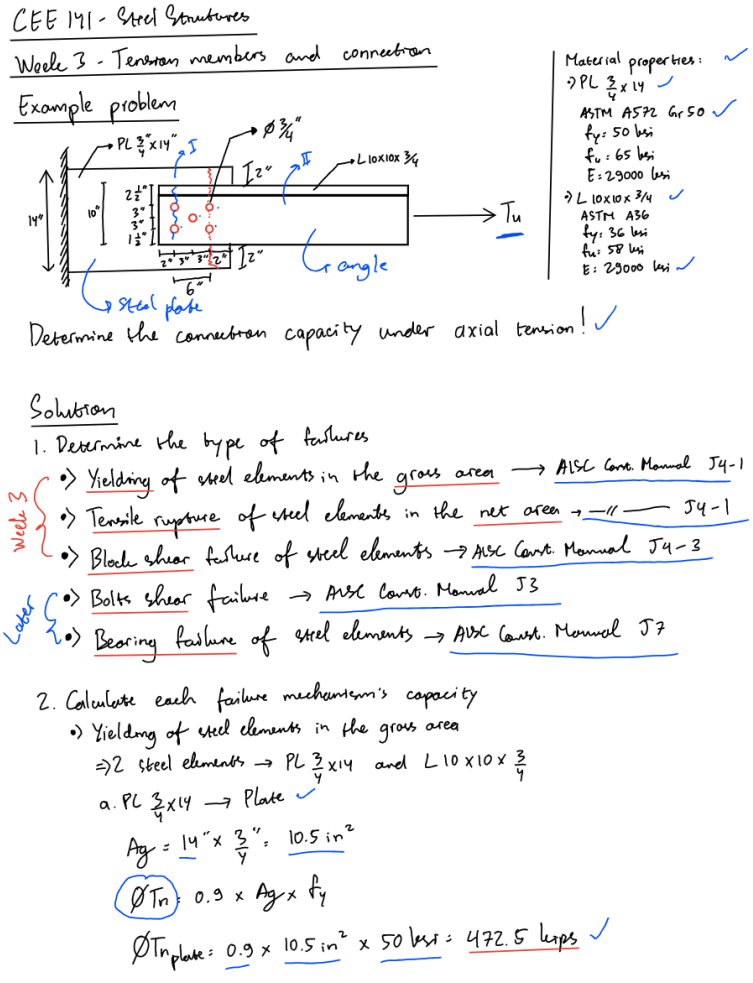




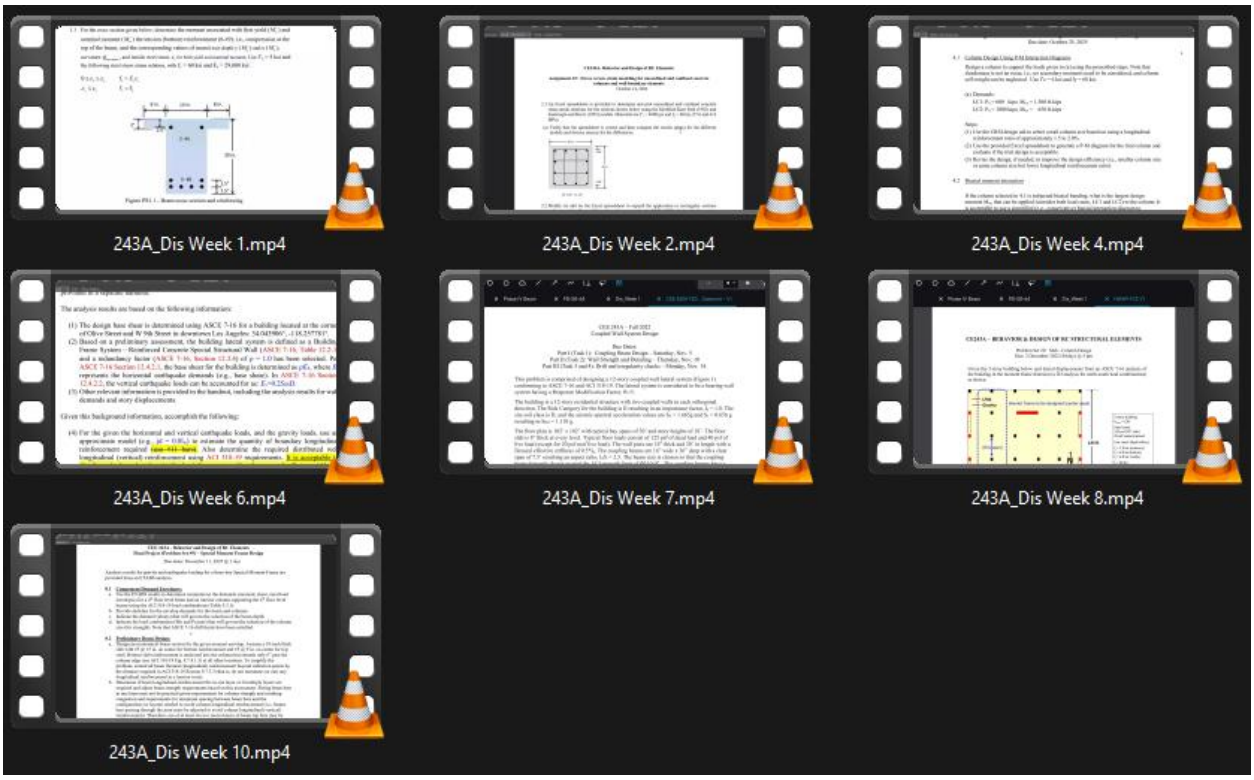


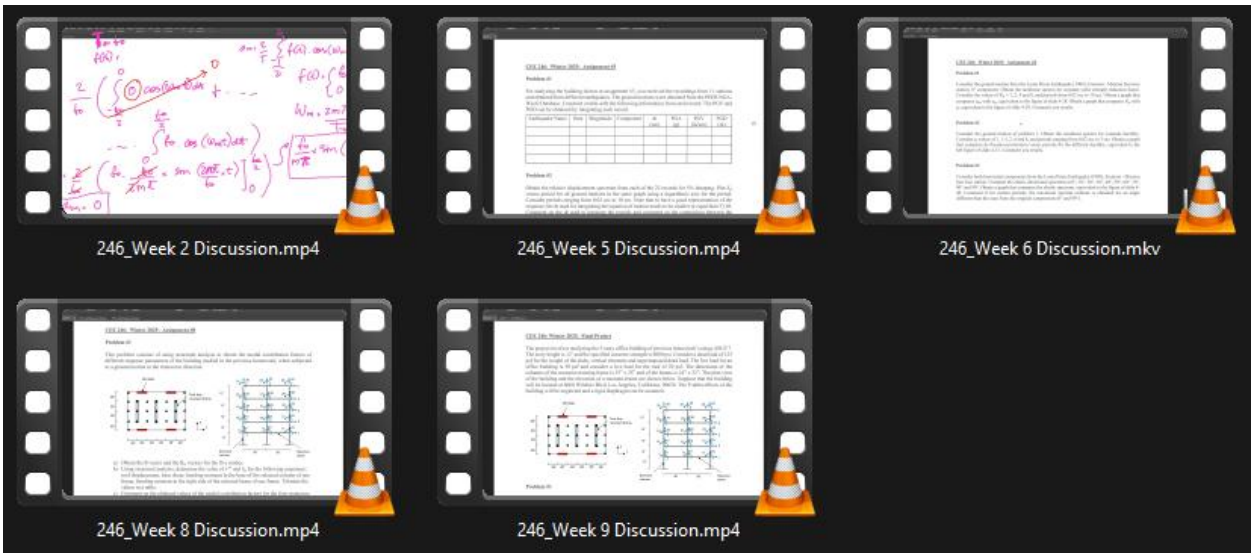
Sample discussion notes:

Prewritten notes and annotated during discussion to help emphasize certain parts of the example problem (CEE141).



Recorded discussion sections are properly organized (CEE 243A and CEE 246):



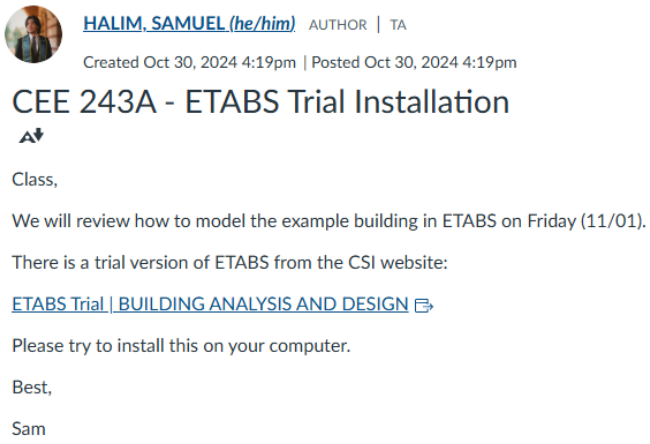


Teaching Artifact #2: ETABS Guidance and Homework

Samuel Halim | 406073724

Observing that many students lacked experience with industry-standard design tools, I proactively introduced ETABS modeling into CEE 243A. My goal was to provide a practical education that closely mirrored professional workflows. I constructed a detailed tutorial covering installation, structural modeling, and seismic analysis, ensuring all students could participate by providing instructions for accessing trial software. Through this initiative, I aimed to challenge students to expand their technical skill sets beyond the traditional syllabus. I was really encouraged by the student feedback attached here, which shows how much they appreciated having a guide that prepares them for the work they will do after graduation.

Software Installation guide:



HALIM, SAMUEL *(he/him)* AUTHOR | TA

Created Oct 30, 2024 4:19pm | Posted Oct 30, 2024 4:19pm

CEE 243A - ETABS Trial Installation

Class,

We will review how to model the example building in ETABS on Friday (11/01).

There is a trial version of ETABS from the CSI website:

ETABS Trial | BUILDING ANALYSIS AND DESIGN

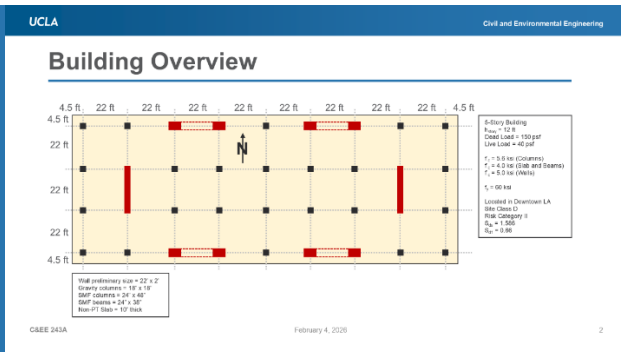
Please try to install this on your computer.

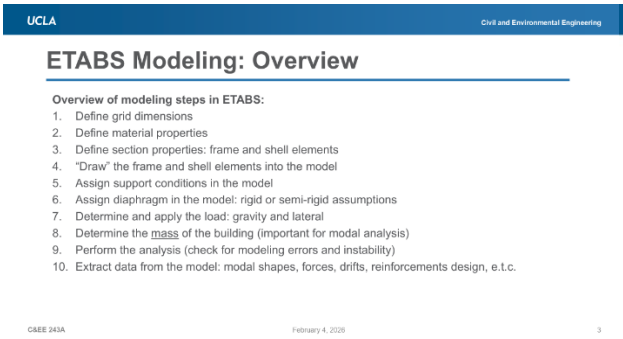
Best,

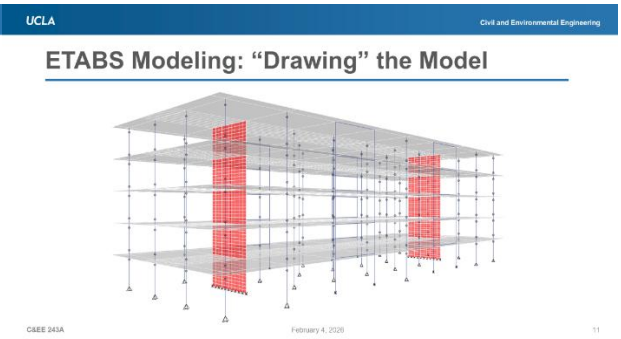
Sam

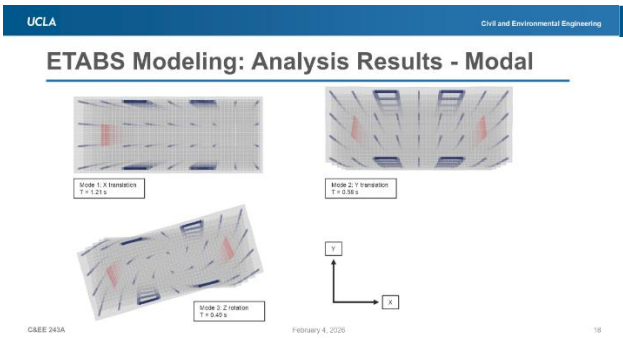
Detailed step-by-step instructions on how to model structures in ETABS (full slides are available upon request):

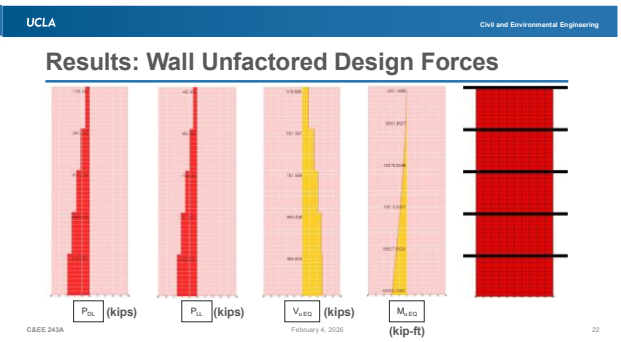








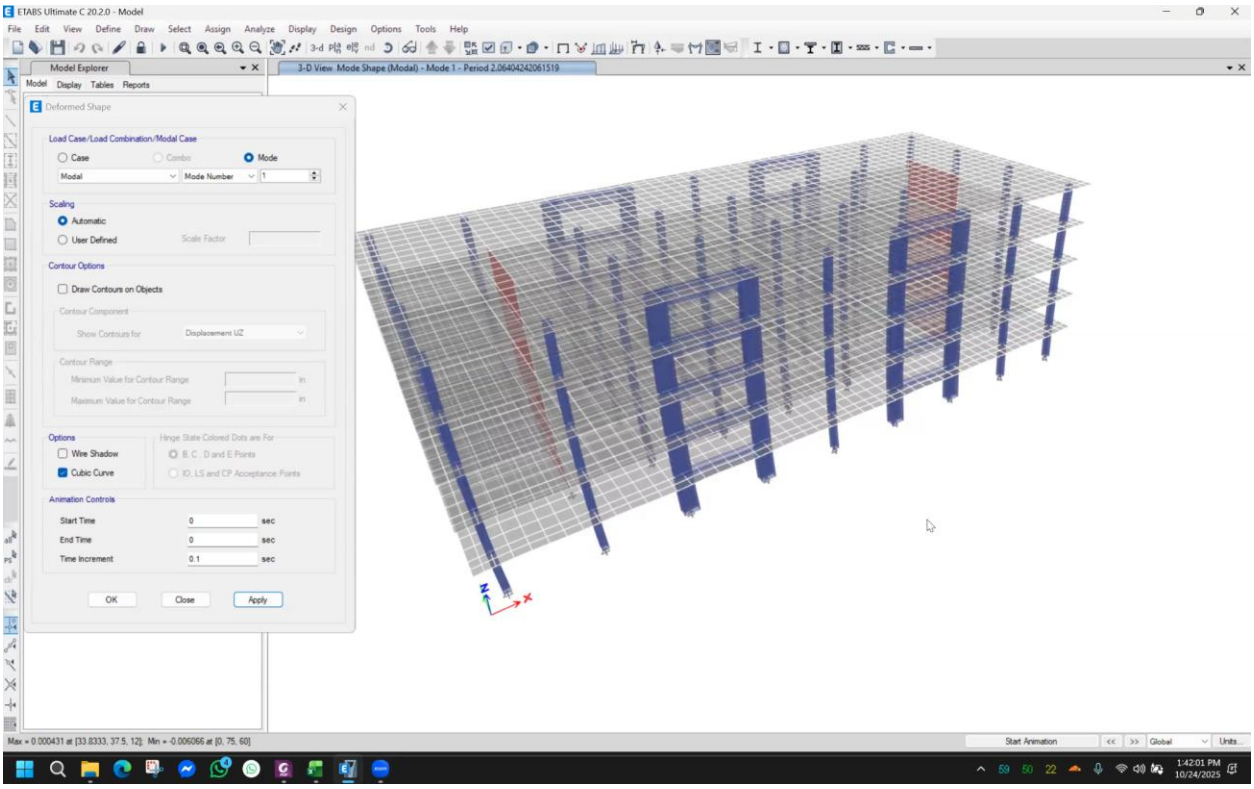




Student feedback:

- Most knowledgeable TA I know. Very chill and kind. This TA should be a professor.
- Sam is amazing. His discussion sections were well organized and he was engaging. It was very obvious that he cared about the students and he made me want to go to class. I would 100% take another class with him.
- Sam is the best TA I've had since he was so knowledgeable about the topics we learned in our class and explained everything thoroughly. I appreciated how he went through the steps to solve our homework assignments since it helped greatly when doing the assignments. Additionally, I appreciated how he took the time to show us how to use ETABS, which was helpful in showing me shortcuts and helpful in the longterm for when I start working in the industry.
- The TA was very helpful and approachable, always present during class hours and readily available to assist students with any questions or difficulties.
- The TA was very useful and showed lots of concern for student learning, more than the instructor. I felt the course was a lot more manageable with the TA's discussion sections. The TA also helped with organizing the course as communication about exams and other class logistics wasn't clear and we had to get the TA to discuss scheduling with the instructor to get information on when exams would be during the quarter.

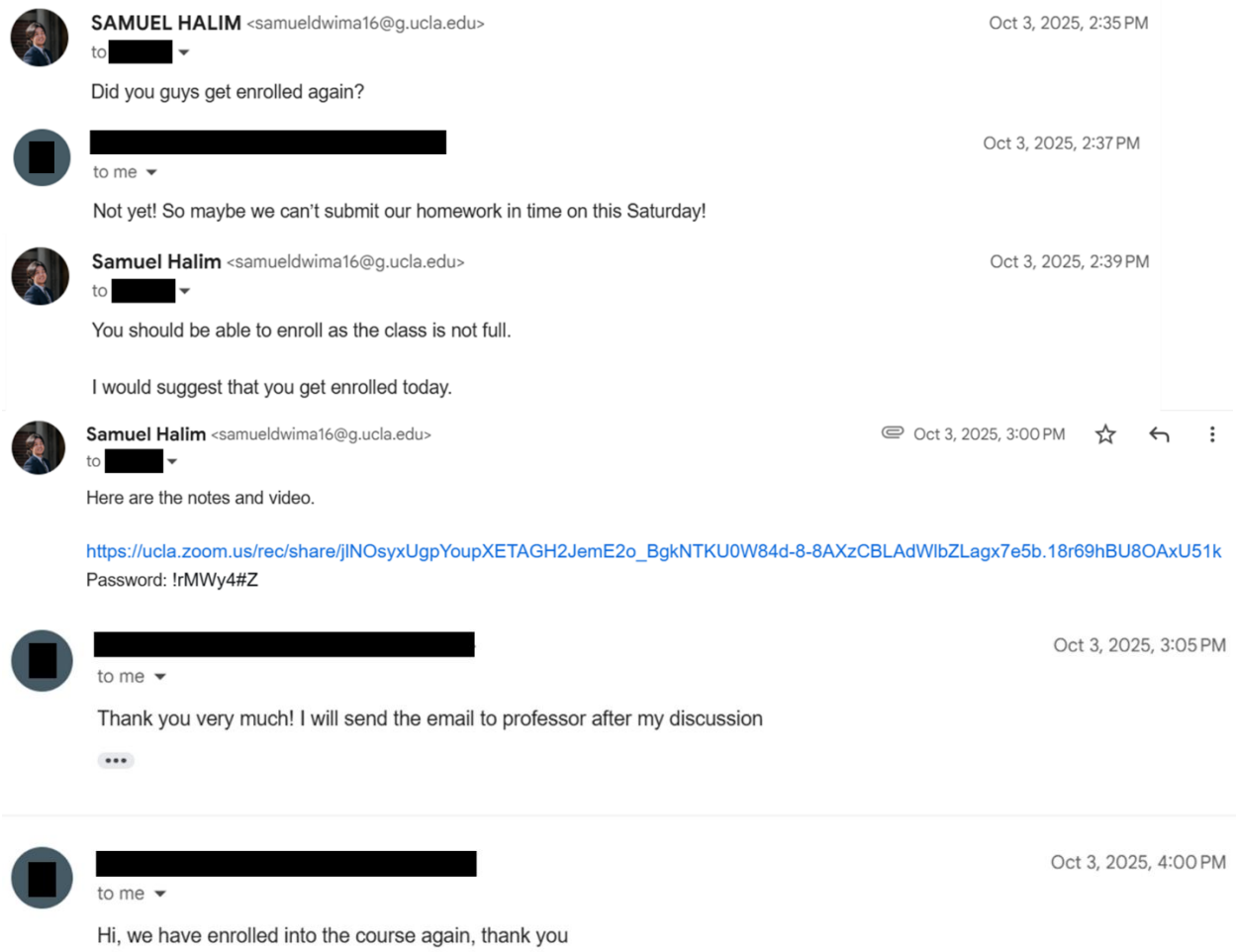
Recordings are provided so students that are unfamiliar with the software can rewatch the discussion and follow the steps to model the building correctly:



Teaching Artifact #4: Empowering Students to Overcome Academic Anxiety

Samuel Halim | 406073724

This artifact highlights a meaningful moment of mentorship during my time as a TA. During some in-person conversations, a few students shared that they had already dropped the course because they were overwhelmed by the difficulty of the material. Knowing how vital this knowledge would be for their future careers, I felt it was important to step in and encourage them to re-enroll. I made a personal commitment to provide the extra support and guidance they needed to navigate the class challenges smoothly. By offering a clear roadmap and a sense of security, I helped them move past their hesitation and successfully complete the course. The email correspondence below shows the transition from their initial discouragement to a successful finish.



SAMUEL HALIM <samueldwima16@g.ucla.edu> Oct 3, 2025, 2:35 PM
to [redacted]

Did you guys get enrolled again?

[redacted] Oct 3, 2025, 2:37 PM
to me

Not yet! So maybe we can't submit our homework in time on this Saturday!

Samuel Halim <samueldwima16@g.ucla.edu> Oct 3, 2025, 2:39 PM
to [redacted]

You should be able to enroll as the class is not full.

I would suggest that you get enrolled today.

Samuel Halim <samueldwima16@g.ucla.edu> Oct 3, 2025, 3:00 PM
to [redacted]

Here are the notes and video.

https://ucla.zoom.us/rec/share/jlNOsyxUgpYoupXETAGH2JemE2o_BgkNTKU0W84d-8-8AXzCBLAdWlbZLagx7e5b.18r69hBU8OAxU51k
Password: !rMWy4#Z

[redacted] Oct 3, 2025, 3:05 PM
to me

Thank you very much! I will send the email to professor after my discussion

[redacted] Oct 3, 2025, 4:00 PM
to me

Hi, we have enrolled into the course again, thank you

Distinguished Teaching Assistant — Letter of Recommendation

This award celebrates Teaching Assistants who demonstrate a pattern of effective teaching that incorporates current best practices (e.g., student-centered learning, active learning, inclusive teaching), aims to inspire and challenge students, and supports the success of all students.

Name

Briefly describe how you know the nominee. (50 words max)

In a few sentences, describe a few ways in which the nominee inspired or challenged you or other students in the class. (200 words max)

Our cohort was infamously known to be quiet during the lecture and sessions throughout the quarter. Samuel recognized this early on and adjusted his teaching approach accordingly. Rather than relying on spontaneous questions or assuming verbal participation, he structured his discussions in a way that guided students through the material while still encouraging engagement when possible.
During the final project, Samuel shared an example of his own work from his year. The level of detail and clarity in his example and how he guided through his work set a clear benchmark for what was expected and raised the standard and awareness for the entire class. This helped students better understand how to approach the project and what a complete and well thought submission looked like. As a result, the overall quality of the final projects was noticeably strong, and the entire class performed extremely well on the assignment.

Describe one or two things that the nominee did that you thought were particularly beneficial for your (or other students') learning or understanding of concepts. (200 words max)

One thing that Samuel consistently did well was teaching the concepts and steps from the ground up. Among all the other TAs that I had been with so far, he was the one who made it easier for me to understand the material, even when it was conceptually difficult.
In every discussion session, he walked through homework problems step by step and explained the reasoning behind each step rather than skipping to the final answer. He avoided explaining concepts in a purely abstract way, and instead he took the time to draw examples or reference prior material to make the ideas more concrete, even when it required additional time. Because of this, there was always high attendance at his discussion sections, be it in person or even online, as many students relied on them to better understand the homework and course material. Considering how challenging this advanced course is, his ability to explain every step in detail helped me understand the material more deeply, in some cases even beyond what was covered during lecture. I personally feel that completing the homework and project felt impossible without attending his discussion session first.

Please share any additional reasons why you believe the nominee is an outstanding candidate for this award. (100 words max)

Distinguished Teaching Assistant — Letter of Recommendation

This award celebrates Teaching Assistants who demonstrate a pattern of effective teaching that incorporates current best practices (e.g., student-centered learning, active learning, inclusive teaching), aims to inspire and challenge students, and supports the success of all students.

Name Nicholas Lwe

Briefly describe how you know the nominee. (50 words max)

I had Sam as my TA for two core classes during my graduate program.

In a few sentences, describe a few ways in which the nominee inspired or challenged you or other students in the class. (200 words max)

During every discussion, Sam always made sure his students thoroughly understood the concepts at hand by giving us many opportunities to ask questions or trying to answer his questions without any judgment and giving constructive feedback. Sam also incorporated theoretical problems into real life situations, and challenged our thinking by introducing variations of what we were learning. This helped push us to learn how to analyze and think about different situations, rather than just memorize the solution to a predetermined problem.

Describe one or two things that the nominee did that you thought were particularly beneficial for your (or other students') learning or understanding of concepts. (200 words max)

I thought it was very beneficial for our understanding when Sam asked us the "What if" questions to get us to analyze the problem at hand or variations of the problem to get us to really think about the purpose of why and where certain materials are used and what changes when something is different. Sam was also very engaging with the students so it did not feel like we were just reading and writing down words and figures from the board. He always found ways to bring us into the discussions to participate and do the work with him, and made sure we were all on the same page before moving forward.

Please share any additional reasons why you believe the nominee is an outstanding candidate for this award. (100 words max)

I truly believe Sam is an outstanding candidate for this award because in addition to being an amazing TA that helps all of his students learn and understand structural engineering concepts well, he teaches in a fashion that encourages students to want to engage in the discussion and challenges our critical thinking and engineering judgment skills to see if we do understand the concepts and if we can recognize when a design or measurement is reasonable or not. I personally feel that he set up me for success for my career in civil engineering and gave the program more worth.

Distinguished Teaching Assistant — Letter of Recommendation

This award celebrates Teaching Assistants who demonstrate a pattern of effective teaching that incorporates current best practices (e.g., student-centered learning, active learning, inclusive teaching), aims to inspire and challenge students, and supports the success of all students.

Name

Briefly describe how you know the nominee. (50 words max)

In a few sentences, describe a few ways in which the nominee inspired or challenged you or other students in the class. (200 words max)

Describe one or two things that the nominee did that you thought were particularly beneficial for your (or other students') learning or understanding of concepts. (200 words max)

Please share any additional reasons why you believe the nominee is an outstanding candidate for this award. (100 words max)

PONTIFICIA
UNIVERSIDAD
CATÓLICA
DE CHILE

February 5, 2026

To: Evaluation Committee, UCLA Distinguished Teaching Assistant Award

Subject: Letter of Support: Samuel Halim | Distinguished TA Award Nominee

It is a pleasure to support Mr. Samuel Halim for the Distinguished Teaching Assistant Award. I write this as an Associate Professor and Director of the Department of Structural and Geotechnical Engineering at the Pontifical Catholic University of Chile (PUC), where I have served since 2009. During my eight-month sabbatical at UCLA, which included the Winter 2025 quarter, I worked closely with Samuel within Professor John Wallace's research group. Our frequent interactions across various activities, including the course CEE 246 (Structural Response to Ground Motion [Graduate level]), laboratory work, research meetings, and even lunches, provided me with a clear and comprehensive view of his capabilities and character.

As this was my first time teaching at UCLA, Sam had been a great help to support my transition. He helped extensively with integrating course materials and software demonstrations to help the students understand better. We had weekly meetings to discuss the current state of the class so he could prepare the discussions to be integral to the course. More than that, Samuel possesses a rare level of empathy for his students and their learning process. He showed constant concern for the well-being of the students, making each of them feel important and supported. The course received outstanding evaluations, and Samuel's performance as a Teaching Assistant was excellent, with an SET score of 8.73/9.00.

From my perspective, Samuel actively promoted values that are of great importance within our academic community: excellence, human dignity, respect, integrity, and responsibility. He is great at motivating students and helping them find the confidence to solve problems on their own. Samuel does not merely deliver content; he motivates students for their learning and acts as a partner in their success. I recommend him for this award without reservation.

Sincerely yours,



Matías Hube Ph.D.
Chair, Department of Structural and Geotechnical Engineering
School of Engineering
Pontificia Universidad Católica de Chile